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Caring for the Dead: Ma'nene in Toraja, Indonesia

1. The Practice, Its Origin, and Why It Is Taboo in America

Ma'nene is a practice of the Toraja, an ethnic group in the highlands of South Sulawesi, Indonesia. Families open the graves of relatives who died years or even decades before, take out their bodies, dry and clean them, and then wrap them in fresh cloth or dress them in new clothes before returning them to the tomb. According to photographer and journalist Agung Parameswara (2015), the Toraja in the village of Pangala do this in August, the period between harvest and planting, and he saw relatives talking to the dead and introducing them to newer members of the family.

The ritual originated from the traditional belief system of the Toraja called Aluk Todolo, which is based on ancestor spirits. According to Parameswara (2015), a hunter named Pong Rumasek prospered after respectfully dressing and burying a body that he found in the forest, which taught the people of his village to treat the dead with respect, and the practice started to spread throughout the region. In addition, anthropologists at Hasanuddin University, Putra et al. (2023), explain that the ritual began as a way of honoring ancestors and seeking their blessing, but many Christian Toraja now understand it as an expression of love, gratitude, and care because they believe blessings come only from God. Their fieldwork also revealed that it is not always performed every year because it depends on a family's money and willingness to do it.

It is taboo in America because our societal norms surrounding death are almost the opposite.

Bodies are mostly handled by professionals, put away, and left alone, and disturbing a grave is a crime, not to mention highly disrespectful to most of us. Many Americans would see relatives handling a corpse as a violation, whereas for the Toraja, it is quite the opposite of neglect.

2. Living With a Roommate Who Practices It

If my roommate came from a Toraja family, the first thing I would do is ask them to tell me about it, but only if they felt comfortable. I would probably feel some uneasiness in the beginning, and I would not pretend otherwise to myself. However, this feeling would stem from my upbringing and not from concrete evidence that the practice is wrong. Being ethnocentric means judging another culture as worse by one's own standards, whereas cultural relativism means understanding a practice in the context of the culture it is part of. I would rather be on the side of the latter because the families speak of the ritual as an expression of love and filial responsibility toward those they miss. My personal value of respecting family is the same sentiment, just expressed in a completely different way.

Respect goes both ways, but cultural relativism is not an excuse to violate the rights and safety of others, so I would expect no human remains in our living space and no pressure for me to participate. Those are reasonable limits, and a roommate agreement can address them, but asking with genuine curiosity would benefit both of us more than avoiding the issue. If they preferred not to share, I would accept that too, because a cultural difference should never stop me from treating them as an individual.

3. The Speech

I would give an informative speech, not a persuasive one, because my purpose is not to convince the audience to adopt the practice or to defend every step of it, but to explain Ma'nene to them.

Advocacy is not appropriate for a speaker who is an outsider, my classmates did not ask to be recruited, and the practice involves complicated issues such as consent, tourism, and religious change that the Toraja themselves discuss. An ethical speaker should acknowledge those issues and not promote a conclusion that the evidence does not support. Audience analysis also points to the same approach. Most of my classmates will likely be Americans who find the subject distasteful, so I should start with something we all share: every culture has a way to remember the dead.

As for visual aids, I would bring a map of Sulawesi, a timeline or diagram of the ritual's steps, and a picture of traditional tongkonan houses and stone tombs. I would limit my images to those that families have allowed to be shared publicly, and I would credit the sources. I would avoid close-up pictures of the bodies because they would disturb the audience and draw attention away from the meaning of the practice. Additionally, I would include a slide comparing an American funeral custom with Ma'nene so the audience can see both as ways of grieving.

For language, I would choose words that are calm, neutral, and respectful. Instead of creepy, bizarre, or weird, I would say remains, ancestors, and families. I would also avoid describing the Toraja people as primitive or with any other single label, because practices differ from village to village within the region. I would briefly explain terms such as Aluk Todolo and patane (family grave houses), cite my sources out loud during the speech, and invite questions at the end.

References

Parameswara, A. (2015, November 3). *Bringing out the dead*. Roads & Kingdoms.

<https://roadsandkingdoms.com/2015/bringing-out-the-dead/>

Putra, A. S., Hijjang, P., & Tang, M. (2023). Ethnographic study of symbolic meanings in the Ma'nene' Toraja ritual series. *Journal of Asian Multicultural Research for Social Sciences Study*, 4(2), 73-78. <https://doi.org/10.47616/jamrsss.v4i2.436>